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Scriptio continua, defectiva, plena
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Scriptio continua, defectiva, plena

How the modern world paradoxically lessened their tendency to interpret while gaining a larger capacity for knowledge

IoT Mote
Oct 18

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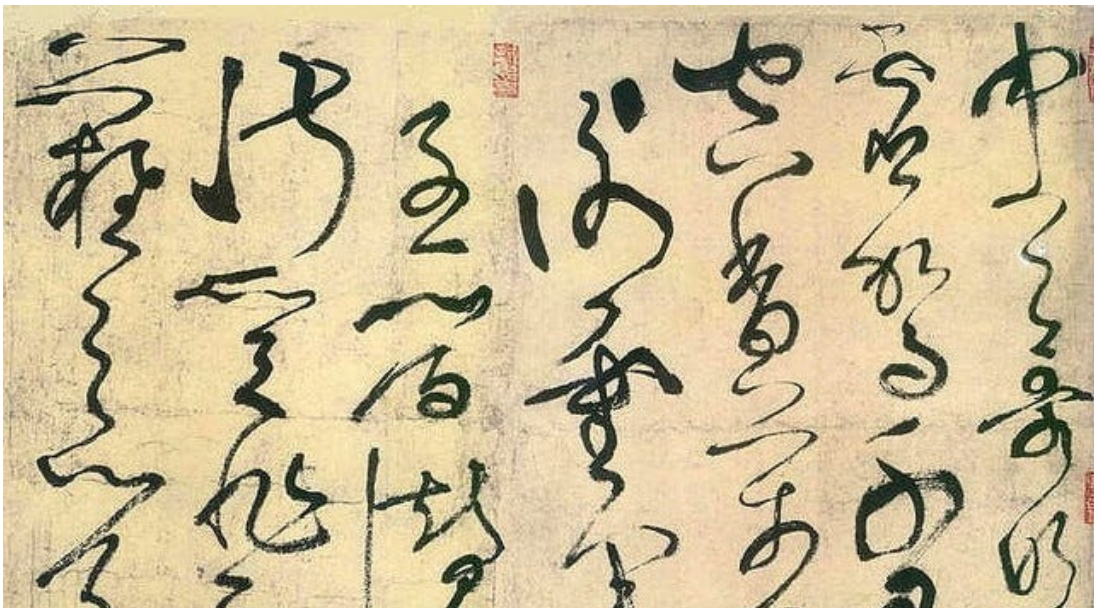

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"***Scriptio continua*** (Latin for "continuous script"), also known as ***scriptura continua*** or ***scripta continua***, is a style of writing without spaces or other marks between the words or sentences. The form also lacks punctuation, diacritics, or distinguished letter case. In the West, the oldest Greek and Latin inscriptions used word dividers to separate words in sentences; however, Classical Greek and late Classical Latin both employed *scriptio continua* as the norm.[1][2]"

"The lack of word parsing forced the reader to distinguish elements of the script without a visual aid, but it also presented the reader with more freedom

to interpret the text. The reader had the liberty to insert pauses and dictate tone, which made the act of reading a significantly more subjective activity than it is today. However, the lack of spacing also led to some ambiguity because a minor discrepancy in word parsing could give the text a different meaning. For example, a phrase written in *scriptio continua* as *collectamexiliopubem* may be interpreted as *collectam ex Ilio pubem*, meaning "a people gathered from Troy", or *collectam exilio pubem*, "a people gathered for exile". Thus, readers had to be much more cognisant of the context to which the text referred.[4]"

"In contrast, paleographers today identify the extinction of *scriptio continua* as a critical factor in augmenting the widespread absorption of knowledge in the pre-Modern Era. By saving the reader the taxing process of interpreting pauses and breaks, the inclusion of spaces enables the brain to comprehend written text more rapidly. Furthermore, the brain has a greater capacity to profoundly synthesize text and commit a greater portion of information to memory.[7]:16–17""

"Scriptio continua is still in use in Thai script, other Southeast Asian abugidas: (Burmese, Khmer, Javanese, Balinese, Sundanese script), Lao, and in languages that use Chinese characters (Chinese and Japanese). However, modern vernacular Chinese differentiates itself from ancient *scriptio continua* through its use of punctuation, although this method of separation was borrowed from the West only about a century ago[*clarify*]. Before this, the only forms of punctuation found in Chinese writings were marks to denote quotes, proper nouns, and emphasis. Modern Tibetic languages also employ a form of *scriptio continua*; while they punctuate syllables, they do not use spacing between units of meaning."

It could be said that the Language Poets are a revival of ancient texts that allowed more freedom of interpretation. While Latin texts were not a layman's domain, the responsibility of transcribing texts fell upon the scribe, who wielded at least some influence in determining where the emphasis would lie.

In Koirala, S. (2016). Linking Words with the World: The Language Poetry Mission,

"Language poetry refers to all the different writing practices demonstrated by

a rather loose group of writing communities, mostly printed in magazines such as This, Tottel's, L=A=N=G=U=A=G=E and Poetics Journal."

"Language poetry has made the connection between ideology and form apparent. It has theorized the relationship of form and politics."

"They view writing and criticism through the lens of political work. Indeed, the language poets envision a new reality by means of offering new linguistic forms (Brill 60). The basic instrumental function of language is, thus, diminished. Questioning the nature of language it tries to remove the notions existing with language such as the transcendental ego, the authentic self, poet as a lonely genius, and a unique artistic style. Instead, an anatomy of the dominant society and class discourses in order to subvert itself comes to the prime concern."

A change of the society through changing the language is a remarkable politics of language poetry. The poets desire to change the society by changing the mind, which is a change in poetics. Thus, it is poetry for use. Language poets are for "opposition," whereas mainstream academic poets are for "accommodation," if the terms of McGann are borrowed. The former are objective whereas the latter are subjective. For the language poets subjectivity hinders their desire to change social life. It is difficult for a change-seeking poem to be subjective and social at the same time. Thus, language poetry rejects the totalizing methods that consequently enhance totalitarianism, though it happens in a minor level compared to the real politics for the governance."

"In fact, it is based upon a rejection of Chomskyan linguistics and generative grammar. Silliman's The New Sentence and Watten's Total Syntax, for instance, openly refute Chomsky. Maintaining a criticality of the poetic language these poems treat the objects of their art. Avoiding a unifying aesthetic or style, they are similar to the "series of series," as explained by Foucault. A poem is not merely a poem but a part of a larger system.

Language poets are interested in writing that places its attention largely on language and the ways of making meaning. They dislike taking for granted the language elements such as vocabulary, grammar, process, shape, syntax, or subject matter. Language is used not only as a medium of

communication but also as a material for poetic construction. More than a vehicle to carry preexisting meanings, language is seen as a system with its own operational rules. Language poetry celebrates the “material signifier” by viewing writing as a demonstration of the “materiality of the sign.” Andrews writes in “Text and Context” that “Texts are themselves signifieds, not mere signifiers”"

“Like the depolarization of theory and writing, language poets are committed to emphasize the difference between writing and speech. Programmatic focus on writing rather than speech is a typical feature of language poetry.”

“Experimental poetry is normally political as it intends to subvert or disrupt the dominant representative forms.”

“The typography L=A=N=G=U=A=G=E stops reader’s gaze on letters as things.”

“Equals signs (=) were used in the magazine title with uppercase print. The uppercase used for each letter indicates the idea of “blocks” carrying heavy meanings. **Equal** signs mean that letters are harmoniously connected to each other and all of them are **equal**. Each letter contains the same heaviness and the power of communication.”

“It further shows the equality among writer, text, reader by violating the hierarchy, that is, writer=text=reader. Thus, the title name itself evolves dialectic of theory and practice.”

“In such non-referential poems language is divorced from reference as Stein has done. Additionally, collage, disjunction, spaces, and silences liberate these poems from conventional narrative structures. Bernstein’s “Artifice of Absorption” speaks for a poetics of transparency and opacity. His poetry disfigures the words, opens up syntax, and reduces the signifiers to their sub-verbal elements.

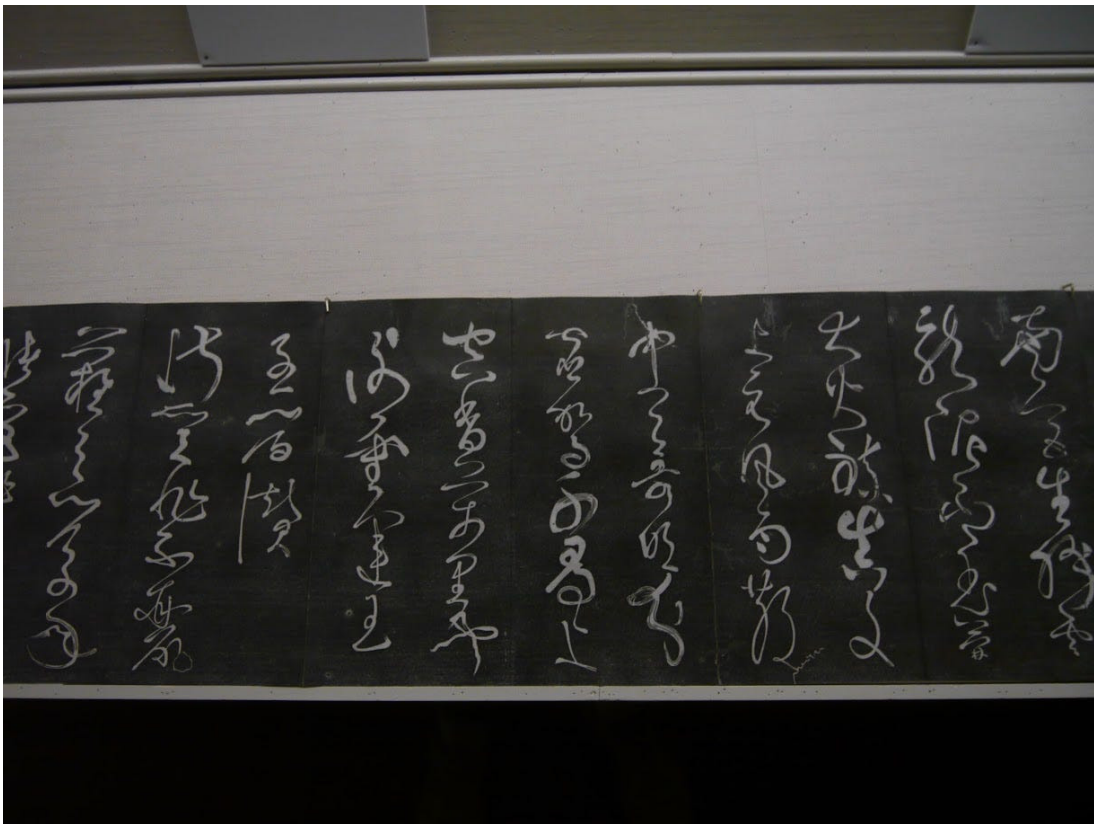
Absorptive & antiabsorptive works both require artifice, but the former may hide this while the latter may flaunt it. & absorption may dissolve into theater as these distinctions chimerically shift & slide. (Bernstein, A Poetics 30)

According to Bernstein the anti-absorptive works flaunt their artifice.

Language poetry endeavors to dramatize such artifice.”

“The sentence fragments are used as complete sentences to challenge the dogmatic rules of grammar. Likewise, the poets use quotation as cultural intervention.”

“**Quotations** sometimes work as report, and enhance resistance. They often suppress the author’s voice. The language poems, thus, create a verbal vortex the reader has to work with. In sum, all the unique tactics and strategies the language poetry displays are directly from a treasure of poetics and they apparently provide energy to the mission the school intended to launch.”



https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Dialectic#Hegelian_dialectic

“On the other hand, Hegel did use a three-valued logical model that is very similar to the antithesis model, but Hegel's most usual terms were: Abstract-Negative-Concrete. Hegel used this writing model as a backbone to accompany his points in many of his works.[28]

For Hegel, the concrete, the synthesis, the absolute, must always pass through the phase of the negative, in the journey to completion, that is, mediation. This is the essence of what is popularly called Hegelian dialectics."

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Dialectical_materialism

"Marx's criticism of Hegel asserts that Hegel's dialectics go astray by dealing with ideas, with the human mind. Hegel's dialectic, Marx says, inappropriately concerns "the process of the human brain"; it focuses on ideas. Hegel's thought is in fact sometimes called **dialectical idealism**, and Hegel himself is counted among a number of other philosophers known as the German idealists. Marx, on the contrary, believed that dialectics should deal not with the mental world of ideas but with "the material world", the world of production and other economic activity.[19] For Marx, a contradiction can be solved by a desperate struggle to change the social world. This was a very important transformation because it allowed him to move dialectics out of the contextual subject of philosophy and into the study of social relations based on the material world.[21]"

From "On Art & Politics" "Dialectical materialism holds that the relationship between literature, art, politics can neither be separated nor **equated**."

This interpretation would explain the emphasis on STEM education in countries like China. In the West, many great schools in the produce graduates with well-rounded educations using the liberal arts and sciences curriculum:

"A liberal arts college or liberal arts institution of higher education is a college with an emphasis on undergraduate study in *liberal arts and sciences*. Such colleges aim to impart a broad general knowledge and develop general intellectual capacities, in contrast to a professional, vocational, or technical curriculum.[1] Students in a liberal arts college generally major in a particular discipline while receiving exposure to a wide range of academic subjects, including sciences as well as the traditional humanities subjects taught as liberal arts. Although it draws on European antecedents,[2] the liberal arts college is strongly associated with American higher education, and most liberal arts colleges around the world draw explicitly on the American model.

There is no formal definition of liberal arts college, but one American authority defines them as schools that "emphasize undergraduate education and award at least half of their degrees in the liberal arts fields of study."[3] Other researchers have adopted similar definitions.[4]”

“To describe the activity of overcoming the negative, Hegel also often used the term *Aufhebung*, variously translated into English as "sublation" or "overcoming", to conceive of the working of the dialectic. Roughly, the term indicates preserving the useful portion of an idea, thing, society, etc., while moving beyond its limitations. (Jacques Derrida's preferred French translation of the term was *relever.*)[32]”

“As in the Socratic dialectic, Hegel claimed to proceed by making implicit contradictions explicit: each stage of the process is the product of contradictions inherent or implicit in the preceding stage. For Hegel, the whole of history is one tremendous dialectic, major stages of which chart a progression from self-alienation as slavery to self-unification and realization as the rational constitutional state of free and equal citizens. The Hegelian dialectic cannot be mechanically applied for any chosen thesis. Critics argue that the selection of any antithesis, other than the logical negation of the thesis, is subjective. Then, if the logical negation is used as the antithesis, there is no rigorous way to derive a synthesis. In practice, when an antithesis is selected to suit the user's subjective purpose, the resulting "contradictions" are rhetorical, not logical, and the resulting synthesis is not rigorously defensible against a multitude of other possible syntheses. The problem with the Fichtean "thesis–antithesis–synthesis" model is that it implies that contradictions or negations come from outside of things. Hegel's point is that they are inherent in and internal to things. This conception of dialectics derives ultimately from Heraclitus.

Hegel stated that the purpose of dialectics is "to study things in their own being and movement and thus to demonstrate the finitude of the partial categories of understanding."[34]”

Thus, a dialectic materialist may believe that solving problems in the material world is a one-way trip to dialectical materialism. To Hegel, “the whole of history is one tremendous dialectic,” emphasizing neither idealism nor materialism, and stating it “cannot be mechanically applied for any chosen

thesis." It is also illogical and impossible to base a material world as a foundation of all prior knowledge. Knowledge, whether it is material science, engineering, or of art or literature, arises from experiential study, and experiential study arises from ideas or free will. A bias on towards one branch of university causes an imbalance in stasis:

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Unity_of_opposites

"Dialecticians claim that unity or identity of opposites can exist in reality or in thought. If the opposites were completely balanced, the result would be stasis, but often it is implied that one of the pairs of opposites is larger, stronger or more powerful than the other, such that over time, one of the opposed conditions prevails over the other. Yet rather than 'stasis' the identity of opposites, there being unity within their duality, is taken to be the instance of their very manifestation, the unity between them being the essential principle of making any particular opposite in question extant as either opposing force."

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Unity_of_opposites#Modern_philosophy

"In his criticism of Immanuel Kant, the German philosopher Georg Wilhelm Friedrich Hegel tried to systematise dialectical understandings and thus wrote:

"The principles of the metaphysical philosophy gave rise to the belief that, when cognition lapsed into contradictions, it was a mere accidental aberration, due to some subjective mistake in argument and inference. According to Kant, however, thought has a natural tendency to issue in contradictions or antinomies, whenever it seeks to apprehend the infinite. We have in the latter part of the above paragraph referred to the philosophical importance of the antinomies of reason, and shown how the recognition of their existence helped largely to get rid of the rigid dogmatism of the metaphysic of understanding, and to direct attention to the Dialectical movement of thought. But here too Kant, as we must add, never got beyond the negative result that the thing-in-itself is unknowable, and never penetrated to the discovery of what the antinomies really and positively mean. That true and positive meaning of the antinomies is this: that every actual thing involves a coexistence of opposed elements. Consequently to

know, or, in other words, to comprehend an object is equivalent to being conscious of it as a concrete unity of opposed determinations. The old metaphysic, as we have already seen, when it studied the objects of which it sought a metaphysical knowledge, went to work by applying categories abstractly and to the exclusion of their opposites.[2]”

“***Coincidentia oppositorum***

Eliade claims that many myths, rituals, and mystical experiences involve a "coincidence of opposites," or *coincidentia oppositorum*. In fact, he calls the *coincidentia oppositorum* "the mythical pattern."[104] Many myths, Eliade notes, "present us with a twofold revelation":

they express on the one hand the diametrical opposition of two divine figures sprung from one and the same principle and destined, in many versions, to be reconciled at some *illud tempus* of eschatology, and on the other, the *coincidentia oppositorum* in the very nature of the divinity, which shows itself, by turns or even simultaneously, benevolent and terrible, creative and destructive, solar and serpentine, and so on (in other words, actual and potential).[105]

Eliade argues that "Yahweh is both kind and wrathful; the God of the Christian mystics and theologians is terrible and gentle at once."[89] He also thought that the Indian and Chinese mystic tried to attain "a state of perfect indifference and neutrality" that resulted in a coincidence of opposites in which "pleasure and pain, desire and repulsion, cold and heat [...] are expunged from his awareness".[89]

According to Eliade, the *coincidentia oppositorum'*s appeal lies in "man's deep dissatisfaction with his actual situation, with what is called the human condition".[106] In many mythologies, the end of the mythical age involves a "fall", a fundamental "ontological change in the structure of the World".[107] Because the *coincidentia oppositorum* is a contradiction, it represents a denial of the world's current logical structure, a reversal of the "fall".

Also, traditional man's dissatisfaction with the post-mythical age expresses itself as a feeling of being "torn and separate".[106] In many mythologies, the lost mythical age was a Paradise, "a paradoxical state in which the contraries

exist side by side without conflict, and the multiplications form aspects of a mysterious Unity".[107] The *coincidentia oppositorum* expresses a wish to recover the lost unity of the mythical Paradise, for it presents a reconciliation of opposites and the unification of diversity:"

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